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Select Committee adaptation report generally positive but lacks detail

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The Finance and Expenditure Select Committee today released its report on the Inquiry into Climate Adaptation.

“The report is a good start and picks up on many of the design recommendations in EDS’s recent climate adaptation report. However it lacks detail on many important components of a new system,” said EDS Policy Director Raewyn Peart.

“On the positive side, the Select Committee confirms there needs to be a comprehensive national framework for climate adaptation set out in legislation. It also recommends a wide range of objectives and principles to guide the framework.

“These include minimising long-term societal costs, supporting fairness and equity, upholding te Tiriti o Waitangi, improving access to quality information, and factoring in co-benefits including emissions reductions and improving biodiversity.

“There are also recommendations to establish a lead agency on climate adaptation, to factor in climate adaptation into all government decisions on infrastructure and planning, including Resource Management Act replacement laws, and to develop bespoke arrangements for whenua Māori.

“What the Select Committee has not grappled with in any depth is the issue of compensation and funding. Although recommending that any compensation scheme should focus on adequate housing provision rather than wealth preservation, it does not state whether property owners should receive any compensation at all, or how compensation should be calculated. It also fails to address the issue of where funding for climate adaptation might come from.

“Government will need to work up these broad recommendations into more detailed propositions for a new Climate Adaptation Act. Key elements which EDS considers need to be included are:

- A clear purpose for the Act
- Mandatory regional climate change risk assessments
- A statutory framework for local adaptation planning
- A National Adaptation Fund
- A managed retreat compensation scheme
- A National Adaptation Agency to oversee managed retreat
- Climate Adaptation Reserves for vacated land.

“Immediate action needs to be taken to prevent development from occurring in high hazard areas.

“A very positive aspect of the Select Committee report is that there is cross-party agreement on the recommendations. It is crucial that this cross-party consensus is maintained while more detailed policy is developed,” concluded Ms Peart.

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The EDS report setting out design recommendations for a Climate Adaptation Act is available [here](#).

The Select Committee report is available [here](#).

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